



Shining star: Arjun Erigaisi transformed his steady rise of 2023 into a disruptive breakthrough in 2024, gaining over 60 Elo points to breach the elusive 2800 rating mark.

FIDE/MICHAŁ WALUSZA

Swiss victories and five Indians qualifying for the Candidates Tournament, 2024 was the year when all the stars aligned, as the Indian chess ecosystem delivered a perfect season.

While Gukesh dominated the year, the brother-sister duo of Praggnanandhaa and Vaishali initially stole the spotlight. In January, Praggnanandhaa surpassed Viswanathan Anand to become the highest-ranked Indian in the live ratings. That same month, Vaishali, only the third Indian woman to earn the GM title after Koneru Humpy and Harika Dronavalli, was conferred the Arjuna Award, while their coach, R.B. Ramesh, received the Dronacharya Award for his years of

behind-the-scenes work nurturing Chess Gurukul's talent.

Vaishali's breakthrough came with her triumph at the FIDE Grand Swiss, which earned her a spot in the prestigious Candidates Tournament. For Ramesh, this recognition felt like a validation of his years of tireless effort, marking him as one of the finest contemporary trainers in chess.

Among this wave of success, another name quietly rose to prominence — Arjun Erigaisi. The Warangal GM transformed his steady rise of 2023 into a disruptive breakthrough in 2024, gaining over 60 Elo points to breach the elusive 2800 rating mark. Arjun became only the 16th player in history and the second Indian after Anand to achieve this feat. His relentless, high-risk approach propelled him to a peak rating of 2809.3, making him World No. 2 and the holder of the 14th-highest peak rating in chess history.

Arjun's 2024 campaign was

nothing short of sensational. He began with a victory at the Menorca Open in April and continued his streak with a dominant performance at the Stepan Avagyan Memorial 2024, clinching the title with a round to spare.

His stellar year included a second-place finish at the TePe Sigeman Chess Tournament and a joint-fifth spot at the Sharjah Masters Open. His incredible 10/11 performance on Board 3 earned him both individual and team gold for India at the Budapest Chess Olympiad. Arjun capped off his year with a triumph at the WR Chess Masters Cup in London, outplaying an elite field including Anand, Alireza Firouzja, Nodirbek Abdusattorov, Maxime Vachier-Lagrave, Praggnanandhaa, and Vidit.

Gukesh, meanwhile, proved his mettle not once, not twice, but on three high-stakes occasions, cementing his place among the elite in global chess.

The first of these triumphs came